Lesson 45: The Language of Argument

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 5.10 Language Toolkit; 5.11 Takeaways.

In this lesson

You will learn fifteen key academic words for describing arguments: words for disagreement, logical relationships, reasoning and evaluation. You will practice their meanings, word forms and grammar patterns, review the sentence patterns for concession and counterargument, and look back at the whole argument chapter. These words appear constantly in research writing, including psychology articles (correlation, factor, findings, valid).

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Use fifteen argumentation terms with the right meaning, word form and grammar pattern.
- Explain the difference between correlation and causation, and between random and arbitrary.
- Choose the right language for each part of a concession/counterargument paragraph.
- Analyze a persuasive text with the terms and strategies from Lessons 40 to 45.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
perspective (n)	a position, point of view or attitude; sometimes shaped by a person's experience or identity	My grandmother has lived long enough to have a broader perspective.
con·tro·VER·sial (adj)	causing a debate of strong opinions on different sides	Wilde was a controversial author; many loved him, but many hated him.
pro·PO·nent / op·PO·nent (n)	someone who supports / is against an idea, a plan or another person	Opponents of bilingual education may argue that it doesn't work, but they're mistaken.
cau·SA·tion (n)	proof that one event really did cause another	...there wasn't enough evidence to show causation.
consistent (adj)	matching; making a predictable pattern; making sense together	The damage to the building is consistent with the theory that an electrical problem caused the fire.
cor·re·LA·tion (n)	two events, actions or amounts that are connected or happen at the same time	Social media use is correlated with low self-esteem.
factor (n)	one part of a cause that has more than one part	Two factors that influence the price of clothing are labor cost and materials cost.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
random (adj)	not following any pattern or rules; unpredictable	Whether you get heads or tails when flipping a coin is purely random.
AR·bi·trar·y (adj)	chosen by a person without a particular reason or a consistent, fair rule	International law protects people from arbitrary imprisonment.
assumption (n)	an idea someone believes without having all the evidence	The professor made the assumption that the student didn't care about the class.
findings (n, usually plural)	the information or answers from research	The findings of the clinical trial contradicted our prediction.
contradiction (n)	two statements or actions by the same person that cannot both be true	She pointed out a contradiction between the government's ideas and its actual policy.
cred·i·BIL·i·ty (n)	the quality of deserving to be believed and trusted	After they were wrong about a major election, the polling organization lost credibility with the public.
valid (adj)	reasonable, sensible, acceptable, logical	The economist made a valid point that a livable minimum wage is a different amount in different countries.

Rules and explanations

Word forms and grammar patterns

Term	Related forms (from the book)	Patterns to notice
perspective	count noun	a perspective on something; a different / broader / historical perspective
controversial	controversy (count or non-count noun)	a controversial issue / author / decision
proponent, opponent	propose (verb); oppose (verb), opposition (non-count noun)	proponents of X; opponents of X; oppose X (no preposition); opposition from someone
cause	cause (usually a count noun; also a verb); causal (adj); causation (non-count noun)	one cause of X; X caused Y; a causal relationship between X and Y
consistent	inconsistent; consistency, inconsistency (nouns); consistently, inconsistently (adverbs)	consistent with X
correlation	correlated (adj)	a correlation between X and Y; X is correlated with Y
factor	count noun	an important factor in…; confounding factors
random		a random sample
arbitrary	arbitrarily (adv)	an arbitrary decision; arbitrarily chosen

Term	Related forms (from the book)	Patterns to notice
assumption	assume (verb + object or that-clause)	make the assumption that…; based on the assumption that…
findings	usually plural	the findings of a study indicated / contradicted…
contradiction	contradict (verb + object); contradictory (adj)	a contradiction between X and Y; X contradicts Y
credibility	credible (adj)	establish / lose credibility; a credible source
valid	validity (non-count noun)	a valid point / question; an argument lacks validity

Meanings to keep apart

- **Correlation vs. causation.** A correlation means two things happen together. Causation means one really caused the other "in a way we can prove." The book's example: at first, people thought drinking coffee caused lung cancer, but coffee drinking was correlated with cigarette smoking, which was the actual cause (Lesson 43: false cause).
- **Confounding factors.** "The study designers needed to make sure there were no confounding factors, so they made sure the subjects were evenly distributed between the groups in every way." A confounding factor is a third factor that could explain a result. Psychology experiments deal with such factors in the same way, by making the groups as similar as possible.
- **Random vs. arbitrary.** Both mean "without a pattern," but arbitrary describes a person's decision made without a consistent or fair rule, so it often suggests "unfair" when used about people in power. A coin toss is random. "Was there a system for choosing which students were called on? No, it was the teacher's arbitrary decision."
- **Valid.** In logic, a valid syllogism is one whose conclusion must follow from its premises (Lesson 42). In everyday academic use, a valid point or question is reasonable and acceptable.

Review: the language of the chapter

- **Concession and counterargument** (Lesson 44): show whose perspective you are presenting, and signal each change of perspective. The same language also works in smaller pieces, inside a single sentence.
- **Refuting fallacies** (Lesson 43): source + reporting phrase + paraphrase; transition + fallacy; explanation.
- In this chapter you identified ethos, pathos and logos; analyzed syllogisms; found, named and refuted fallacies; compared perspectives with concession and counterargument; and practiced hedging.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Non-count nouns such as credibility, causation, validity, opposition (and evidence) have no plural in English: write "more evidence", not "evidences". Findings, in contrast, is almost always plural.

Practice

Exercise 1: Argumentation terms review. Choose the best word for each blank from the three choices in brackets. Use the meaning and the grammar pattern to help you decide.

1. The union was negotiating for a pay raise _____ with the cost of living for the region. (opponent/consistent/random)
2. Opponents of a boycott raised a _____ point, that the boycott might actually hurt the workers it was meant to help. (valid/findings/factor)
3. After the scientists recorded the amount of pesticides in the runoff from the cotton fields, they presented their _____ at an environmental health conference. (credibility/random/findings)
4. The decision to strike was _____; some of the workers were convinced it was the only path forward, but others were afraid to lose their jobs or even face retaliation. (contradiction/controversial/correlation)
5. The lack of economic opportunities in rural areas is one _____ driving many women to move to cities in search of factory jobs. (factor/arbitrary/assume)
6. Research on decision-making shows that when we feel a _____ between our behavior and our values, such as when we are shopping for unethically-made products, we feel very uncomfortable, and usually change our values to match our behavior. (consistent/credibility/contradiction)

Exercise 2: Word forms. Complete each sentence from the book with the right form of the word in brackets. Cover the lesson material first.

1. Several members of the city council _____ the new zoning regulations. (opponent)
2. The garment workers union faced considerable _____ from the company when they began to organize. (opponent)
3. There were too many complicated factors for scientists to easily prove a _____ relationship between the specific chemicals polluting the water and rising cancer rates. (cause)
4. Sales have been _____; sometimes higher than expected, sometimes lower. (consistent)
5. Studies _____ reported better outcomes for girls with more years of education. (consistent)
6. The investigators noticed _____ in the two suspects' stories. (consistent)
7. There is a direct _____ between levels of union membership and equal distribution of wealth in a country. (correlated)
8. The factory owner gave an _____ chosen number of workers the day off, but wouldn't explain his decision. (arbitrary)
9. The factory owners correctly _____ that customers would not boycott the brand even if they kept the workers from unionizing. (assumption)
10. The writer _____ his own idea when he says that boycotts are the only solution and also that boycotts are a terrible plan. (contradiction)
11. The safety plan had _____ rules: it stated that workers were required to stand six feet apart, but also that there could be up to 40 people in a small room. (contradiction)

12. The report suggesting the chemical was safe came from a company manufacturing that same chemical, so I don't think that's a _____ source. (credibility)
13. His argument lacks _____; it's true that we all need clothing, but that doesn't mean we all need a new outfit every single time we go out. (valid)
14. The engineers _____ a different solution to the polluted runoff from the fabric dyeing station. (proponent)

Exercise 3: Which part of the paragraph? In a concession/counterargument paragraph, does each phrase usually begin Part 1 (the other perspective), Part 2 (evidence for it) or Part 3 (your response)?

1. Skeptics of [my idea] contend that…
2. They cite research showing that…
3. Nevertheless, …
4. Granted, …
5. It's understandable that people worry about…
6. Even if this is true, …
7. One objection to [my idea] is that…
8. To illustrate, …
9. Although X is a concern, overall…
10. If X were true, Y wouldn't have [verb]ed…

Speak with your tutor

- "Let's debate a controversial issue: [for example, 'Phones should be banned in university classes']. You are an opponent of my position. After six turns, evaluate my reasoning: did I avoid fallacies, concede fairly and hedge my claims? Then correct my use of terms such as proponent, correlation, factor, assumption and valid."
- "Ask me the reflection questions from the chapter one at a time, for example: 'How do you think different languages or cultures approach argumentation differently?' and 'What concepts in this chapter did you already know from studying math and science?' Push me to give examples, and correct my language."
- "Help me analyze the fast fashion essay from Lesson 40: its major and minor premises, its ethos, pathos and logos, its concession and counterargument, and its hedging."
- "Here are five sentences I wrote about a psychology study, using correlation, causation, factor and findings: [paste]. Do any of them claim more than the study shows?"

Read aloud

Pause at each |.

1. Proponents of the boycott argue | that it will put pressure on the company | to improve working conditions.

2. There is a direct cor·re·LA·tion | between levels of union membership | and equal distribution of wealth in a country.
3. Researchers noticed that patients who took the medication had increased rates of arthritis, | but there wasn't enough evidence | to show cau·SA·tion.
4. The study designers needed to make sure | there were no confounding factors.
5. The decision to strike was con·tro·VER·sial.
6. She raised a perfectly valid question: | do we really need new clothing for every occasion?

Writing task

Find an essay, article, advertisement or political speech, and write an analysis of 250-300 words: what persuasive appeals does the writer use, and are they effective? For a psychology option, choose a news article that reports a psychology study (for example, from the free psychology section of The Conversation) or "Untrustworthy Memories Make it Hard to Shop Ethically" from Lesson 42.

Include:

- the writer's thesis and the syllogism under it (major premise, minor premise);
- at least two appeals (ethos, pathos, logos), each with a specific example;
- any logical fallacy, named and explained;
- whether the writer addresses other perspectives, and how;
- an example of hedging, or a claim that should be hedged;
- your evaluation of how effective the text is;
- at least six terms from this lesson.

Checklist:

- Did you state the writer's thesis and premises clearly?
- Did you support each point about an appeal with a specific example from the text?
- Did you explain each fallacy, not just name it?
- Did you use the terms with the right forms and patterns (correlated with, consistent with, proponents of, oppose without "to")?
- Did you keep non-count nouns singular (evidence, credibility) and findings plural?
- Did you hedge your own evaluation where you cannot be certain?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1. (book) 1. consistent 2. valid 3. findings 4. controversial 5. factor 6. contradiction

Exercise 2.

1. opposed (the present tense, oppose, is also correct)
2. opposition
3. causal
4. inconsistent
5. consistently
6. inconsistencies
7. correlation
8. arbitrarily
9. assumed
10. contradicts
11. contradictory
12. credible
13. validity
14. proposed (propose is also correct)

Exercise 3. 1. Part 1 2. Part 2 3. Part 3 4. Part 1 5. Part 2 6. Part 3 7. Part 1 8. Part 2 9. Part 3 10. Part 3 (However, Still and That said appear in both Part 1 and Part 3 of the book's table: they can introduce the other perspective or the return to yours.)

My notes